

University of California, Berkeley

Speaker Intercom to the customer, right? Like we are all driving towards, how do we increase the number of resolutions that a customer can get from Finn? And so like we make money, they get more automation and scale from their business. Um, and so in principle, like that makes a ton of sense. And for most of our customers, they're like, yeah, that's that's a great model. I think, uh, some of the maybe challenges or obstacles we faced when we first introduced that, because we've had this for two and a half years now. And so we've learned a lot from this. But, um, sometimes customers are not, uh, used to buying in, uh, outcome based or consumption models. And so like if you're like an engineering leader, like, and you pay for AWS and things like that, like you're pretty used to that. But if you're a support leader and you've only ever bought seat based products before, and then you see kind of an up and down, you're getting overages like like that's like, I don't how do I tell my CFO that my bill has changed from month over month? And so how do we help one communicate transparently through the product and through our account teams to make sure that customers understand as like, if you make this change and you're going to see a ton of great results, but this is actually what, what you know, comes out on the other end. Um, I think that helps a lot. Um, and then like, I think just like helping them understand, like when we say resolution, what does that actually mean? So again, back to education. It's educating them in terms of this this motion. Right. Um, and lastly, as intercom pivoted to an AI first model, um, you guys are building new products. And I think especially for incumbent companies, like larger companies, they essentially have to build a startup within the company to make sure that they can build things fast. What are some major challenges that you guys faced in the process, and what tension emerged when disrupting your own businesses? Yeah, so we were pretty quick to this. Um, I think it was like ChatGPT launched. And then that weekend, like our leadership team got together like, this is going to be completely game changing to our company. And so quickly, right? Right after that, we basically, um, kind of ripped everything up from a, from a company perspective. And I think that's actually a really hard thing to do is like a larger business with hundreds of millions of dollars of revenue is like, you, like you already have this machine that is going that is making money. And so to go and say, hey, like, I'm actually going to like tear that down and invest in a thing that has just started is really hard for a company to do because, like, you have this pressure to keep making more money and, you know, in the machine that you've already built. But, um, credit to Owen, who's our CEO. He was like, no, like if you look out, you know, three to five years in advance, like the world is going to be different. It's going to be the opposite. So we have to invest now. So we ripped everything up from, you know, the roadmap, the company strategy, the metrics. We look at, um, the honestly like organizational structure, the values we have. And we kind of restarted the company. Um, alongside that, from a product perspective, we did do the, you know, the cliché thing of startup within a startup, but we actually took it to the next level of like, we created a team and it was like a self-contained, self functioning team. They sat in a different part of the office. They weren't burdened by, like the existing kind of red tape, as the rest of the company kind of went through transformation and they just were like, just build and just build and just go and make that product successful. Uh, and I think like eventually then we then we merged it back in. But like that, getting to escape velocity with the small part of the company was critical. I think the story. Um, next, I

want to turn to you, Rohan. Um, perplexity is setting out to change search, um, and going up against Google and all the other large players, and the usage itself is behavior changing. You guys are essentially creating a new category of how people search and access information. How do you, in your capacity as a VP of Growth and Product responsible for your acquisition? How do you scale adoption when the categories are defined and products are changing every single day? Yeah, I think the magic of it is if you are building something net new and leaning into something net new, that is your acquisition. You're essentially essentially presenting everyone with the choice of you can stay in the old world, or you can go down this new world that is ten x better. The catch is that it actually has to be ten x better. And then the other catch is our competitors also move very, very fast to catch up with us. But I think it's you know, we ask ourselves every single day is are we moving fast enough? Are we staying ahead of everyone by at least a couple of months? Because this AI space moves incredibly fast. And from that, that is our marketing, right? As long as we can keep shipping products that are fundamentally different, fundamentally better, we'll keep acquiring. My next question, actually, um, as we as we see to what you just said, um, the perplexity CEO is actually right here on the stage a couple of weeks back, giving a speech to the Berkeley community and something that he said was he thinks that the mode of perplexity is speed. I'm curious how that shows up in your own work day to day, and how do you actually go about building a growth system that scales well, but also align with the pace of product changes? Yeah. Um, it's spot on. You know, we live and die by just how fast we can move. Um, there are a couple pieces here. One is just who do we hire? Do we hire people that, frankly, get their dopamine hits off of speed and being able to ship and being able to see that impact as quickly as possible. Two do we know how to focus right? Do we, you know, have the intuition of this is something we really want to trickle down on and go all in on. Um, this is something that we're going to wait and see how it actually takes out. And that's incredibly hard, right? To a certain extent, it's a little bit of guessing and you hope your intuition gets you there. And then the last one is, you know, every single person at every layer is empowered. We are incredibly flat organization. There is not like a hierarchy of should I do this? Yes, yes, yes it is. You're in charge of this. The expectation is you are going to move these metrics. You are going to really drive this as aggressively as you can. Awesome. And my last question for you is, um, I'm sure in your role as the VP growth, you've done a ton of experiments. I'm curious in your experiences, like, was there one single experiment that actually moved the needle, um, in a, in an unexpected way? Or are there fairly, um, that you thought would work but didn't actually work so well? And what were the learnings that you took away from those experiences? Yeah, I mean, a lot come to mind. The the UI of how we answer a question is really interesting. If you give a very short answer, what happens if you give a very long answer? What happens? How do you figure out what length of answer and how a user actually wants? We do an endless amount of experimentation on really trying to understand a what answer quality is, and then b what is the right structured answer for that? Um, a ton of unintuitive stuff comes out of that, right? Um, you know, there was something interesting around. Well, if you look specifically at cooking recipes, you actually want a very long answer. It's like almost resembles like a long blog article about the recipe. Um, so you find a lot of these unintuitive things, and then you just keep doubling down and pulling back the layers of it. The other interesting one, this is very specific to like. Pretty classic growth flow is how long should onboarding be if someone opens up perplexity? Do you just drop them right

into. Go ahead, ask a question. We think you'll figure this out. Or do you actually want to slow them down and explain how they're going to get value, where it's going to come from, and almost set them up for success? That's something we're still tinkering with quite a bit, but the winning solution so far has been people more or less figure it out. Super fun. Um, thank you for all those insights. Um, fascinating to hear how each of you, in your own capacity and for different product categories, are navigating the challenges of scaling AI. Um, now I want to switch gears a little bit and focus on how to navigate a career in market growth. Um, my questions actually will be addressed to all of you, so feel free to jump in. Um, first off, uh, you guys are probably all hiring managers at your company. Um, I would just ask what qualities you look for or prioritize when building teams, whatever it. I'll start, I think. And this is like a hard, um. It's not like a skill set. I think it's almost like a mindset that you bring, which is this idea of, like, ownership. Um, and I think ownership shows up in a lot of different ways. And, you know, from, like, uh, things move very, very quickly and, like, the technology is constantly changing. These two companies are like constantly coming out with new things for you to stay on top of. And so this like idea of curiosity, but it's like not enough that you're like enthusiastic about it, but you have to own your own learning to stay on top of everything. Right? And then this, this other idea of like ownership in terms of like if your name is on the work, it's like, you know, owning the metrics, like you got to drive it all the way through, figure out a way like you can't, you know, rely on like, oh, you know, somebody else's job is going to go do this one piece and I'll do this one, like own it to the end. Um, that is something that I look for a lot, um, in candidates because I think, you know, that means that you can learn whatever skills that you don't have because you have so much ownership that you'll pick it up over time. Um, I think it's I mentioned this briefly, but it's been the most helpful person that you can be, that no job is above you and always thinking through like, how can I help other people with their job? And I think that's really how I've navigated my career is what are what are some of the ways that I can work with our security team or our customer success team and like, what are the ways that I can help them make their jobs easier? Because that's ultimately the brand that you will build. No one wants to work with the person that is tough to work with, that is really demanding, that is cranky, that bosses people around. It's really taking that kind of opposite lens of it. I will say a downside to that is sometimes this is the number one feedback that I get from my boss. RO is I say yes to too many things. So that is also a very delicate balance to have to not say yes to everything, um, but really say yes to the most strategic things and help out where you can if you have that special knowledge. Um, the other thing I will say is to leverage your network, as you all are thinking about what's up next if you don't have jobs lined up yet. It's really leveraging your network. And your network could be people that came to us, people that went to Berklee and reaching out to them the same way. I got my first job at Eventbrite by reaching out to the CEO. I got my job at slack by reaching out to the person that had just been hired on to oversee all of account management. I was like, oh, they're building a sales team. Reached out to him. Um, got into OpenAI by leveraging my network in there. So network is a very powerful thing. However, my tip here that I will say to all of you is, um, you should never just reach out to someone and ask them for fifteen minutes to pick their brain. I get no less than two hundred of these messages on LinkedIn every single week, and I wish I could help everyone, but I just absolutely can't. So when you're doing these reach outs and you're going to your network, It's thinking about how can I also be helpful to them. And if I can't be helpful,

how can I be very thoughtful? Can I share a new idea? Can I share something that might help them? But really, what you don't want to do is just ask people for their time. Some people will give it, but those who are really busy are going to have a really hard time doing that. And those are probably the people that you want to talk to. Can I ask a follow up question? Yeah. Of course. I was wondering, could you give an example of something that you said yes to from a stranger or someone that you don't know very well? And what are the things or takeaways for compassion? Yeah. Um, while I'm here today, you reached out to me on LinkedIn. You said, will you come speak at. I was like, you know, uh, all right, how can I go and how can I help out? Kind of going back to, like, the reason I'm in tech is because of someone in tech came and spoke that I was like, you know what? I could do this. So I think you're a perfect example, but, um, it's people reaching out with ideas, with suggestions, with tips all the time. I'm a mom to two little girls and so, you know, people are reaching out with, hey, I learned about this app for kids or this idea over here, you know, whether I'm truly interested or not. And what they're saying, it's really powerful that they took the time to do it and to put something personalized on it. Perfect disclaimer we did not plan that much. Now I actually can I add something to that? Okay. Um, I think that that comment is so powerful and it's so true. One mistake that I think that some people make around network is they don't think to build their network until they need their network, and like the by the time you need it, it's way too late. And if building a network takes actually a long time to nurture and like you all like everybody in this room, like you now have this network, everybody that's talked to each other. But like, people don't take the time to like, follow up with the connection that they already have. And one last thing is that if, let's say you didn't follow up with them or you didn't stay in touch with that person, acknowledge that I also have people all the time that reach out from college and they'll be like, hey, we'd love to catch up again. And I'm like, I don't remember your name anymore. So actually just own that and be like, hey, we went to college together. I realized we have not stayed in touch. I love what you've done. Would you be open to spending some time here? And it's just that different approach that like feels a little less slimy is the wrong word, but like a little more genuine? Not super useful. Yeah. You want to add, um, I mean, something we look out for is just, you know, who's the underdog that very much resonates with the culture of our company. Um, who's the underdog? Who's going to take big risks? We hire a lot of founders, stuff like that. How would you define or like what qualities do you what qualities do you but does a person have that would you make that would make you think about this person like what people are? Um, like, are they willing to join the tiny company that is going up against Google and much larger competitors every day? Have they demonstrated that at other times? Right. Have they tried to spin something up of their own and failed gloriously. You know, that's the kind of stuff where we're like, dang, check Mark. Get him in here. Also, just wanted one reminder for the audience. I think we will have some time at the end for Q&A. So if you just want to scan QR code and your questions, I'll be going through them and we'll try to get them all. Um, but my next question is, um, if you guys are graduating from school today or looking to switch careers, what skill or experiences would you prioritize to break into a top AI startup, especially when you go to market or, um, growth team? And I guess, more importantly, what would you do to stay competitive in the long run? I think, I think for now, and that assumes you want to go to an AI startup like you. You have to be able to be very well versed in it to understand it. To be, um, you have to become technical on it. There's no lab or startup that will hire someone that

doesn't have those basic qualifications. I'm actually seeing right now a lot of the hiring that's being done is people who are far overqualified for the role, because people really want to go to these labs and these top startups. So you have to use your network but also show up really well. If you get that spot of you have to over prepare, over learn, know everything and then also come with perspectives on the company. People love to know they want to hear what you think about it. They want to hear product feedback. They want to hear spicy takes on things that their competitors are doing. So it just continues to go back to like being helpful in that interview process. I'd add to that, um, we are growing so quickly. We are rarely hiring for a very defined role. We are hiring instead for someone who can just take on a lot of stuff, like almost where the puck is going is what we want this person to grow into, which is why we hire overqualified people for seemingly small roles at the time that expand like crazy. Um, and I think that's very hard to demonstrate early on unless you are taking risks in your career trying different things, especially while you're in your MBA and have the opportunity to of, you know, here's something I tried and it did not work, and here's the experience I got from it. And here's the perspective and how it applies to your company. Like, we are looking to try and learn something in an interview. And that is the clear green light of this person can take on a lot, will teach themselves, will grow into a bigger role. Um, I will first off be plus one to both of those. Um, I think that like, learning AI part is like this super, uh, super critical. Maybe one thing I would add is like to, to those two is I actually think that like some of the and it depends on the role you're trying to get. But like if you're trying to go into sales or solutions or success or something like that, a lot of the go to market fundamentals like those concepts are still very valuable, right? And so if you're selling it to enterprise, you still need to understand how you navigate an enterprise organization. You still need to know how to build executive sponsorship. You still need to know how to influence. And so I think something like understanding those core skills as well. But then, you know, understanding how you apply them potentially differently or adapt to the business that you you might be joining is going to be like that last mile that becomes really super important. And my last question of the day before I opened up to Cuna is, can you guys share one trick that you personally use with AI, either in life or work, and how has that changed your perspectives or your productivity? I use ChatGPT study mode all the time. So four months ago, um, my CRO asked me to go figure out our strategy for our entire healthcare and pharma and life sciences vertical. I have zero experience and zero background in it other than I'm a patient. Um, and that was a bit of like, okay, this is one of the most important things that Fiji and Sam want to tackle is healthcare. And on our pursuit to build AGI and and pretty much every single night, weekend free minute I had, I was leveraging study mode to learn all the industry jargon, what they care about, all the processes of clinical trials and actually success from this is just. Last Friday, OpenAI announced that we are doing a huge partnership with UCSF. Every student, doctor, clinician, admin, bus driver is getting ChatGPT and that was me and my team. And so four months ago we had pretty much no, no real healthcare expertise. And we have just sprinted so hard at it. And I think we, um, have many more partnerships like that to come. Yeah. Um, are like, I feel like I try to just use it everywhere I possibly can. So it's like whether it is to like, brainstorm ideas or, um, you know, using tools like pre-draft emails and things like that. But maybe one thing I'll share is, um, I run a conference, um, for the customer success community. That's about eight hundred people. We host a pretty big event in New York every single year. And, you know, it's me and a couple

other people doing everything. Um, and the first couple years, we used to have this, like, um, like in order to get, like, sponsorships, speakers, logistics, anything. It was just like, just email us at this email and like, we'll respond to you. And then when I started intercom, I was like, well, I should test out the product. I'll let me just like, install Finn and and do this myself. And this is the thing that, like changed the game for me was like I trained Finn on like everything I, I knew. And then I hooked it up to our notion database. And then Finn started not only just responding to support questions, but like I actually used it to basically do intake and like handle the inbound in terms of sponsorship and speakers and qualifying and then like, and then logging that back into notion for us. And like that was just it blew my mind because we had we were three people trying to run this like massive conference by ourselves. And it was like, okay, like this is this, this feels for real. I should probably take this job. Um, I have a four month old baby, first time dad, and can say with, like, pure confidence that I have no clue what I am doing on any given day or at like three a m in the middle of the night. Um, it's my party trick is literally just, I ask perplexity. So many embarrassing questions you cannot imagine that can never leak out. And maybe just to bring it back to like the the thing we obsess over is accuracy. And you feel that difference when you're when you're a parent asking questions about the odd situation with a four month old and you want to trust the answer, you want to see the sources. You want to understand where it's coming from. Love that. Um, now, I well, we have a couple of questions here. Um, so I think we might just do, like, rapid fire and go try go through as many as possible. So you guys can just jump in. Um, first question is, is moving across different types of companies a good thing, like from Slack to intercom, does your experiences drive more value than going deep in one area? Everyone go. Great question. Um, you know, I think both are great. I think going deep in one area is great. And I think also having that generalist expertise is really good. Yeah, I would agree. I think you you have to I think it's more nuanced than that. You'd have to kind of like I don't think you could just blanket say, hey, I'm going to just randomly jump across a bunch of different companies and industries. You have to kind of have a purpose as to like why you might be taking that next step. Next question. What are one identifying potential hires? How important is seeing a technical background for protocols comparing to a background in customer research or discovery? The protocol is changing quite a bit. Um, every company is different. Every role is different. If we're hiring an AI focused, you know, role that is iterating on answer quality, we probably want someone with some of that more in depth experience growth. We look for people with more data science type experience is very important. I do think it is moving away from we're seeing a separation where engineers, designers are actually making more product decisions. We don't have these very like stark roles, which I think is a good thing. Um, and so then the PM role becomes more of this. Can you see the larger picture? Can you be the director of the movie, uh, and make it come to life? For sure? Um, how could an MBA student of today starts building a career in go to market with a very broad question. I mean, you'll have to start more junior go to market story I shared about Molly started as an SDR out of GSB. That's what you will have to do. You will not be able to go somewhere. Just real talk as a manager or a senior seller. If you do, it's probably a very small company and maybe a bit more of a risky thing that I would do, because usually companies that are growing really well and well funded want people with expertise. I, I just want to add, um, there's a nuance to it, but like, don't say no to anything. Just keep saying yes. Take on as much as you can and just get as many reps as you can. Eventually you'll have

to start saying no. And that becomes very important. But early on in your career, just take as many swings as you can. Um, question for Robin and Maggie. Pretend that you're not listening. How are you guys planning to compete with OpenAI? Okay, so we get this question all the time. Um, first off, we're still here, right? Like any for the last two and a half, three years, we get this question every month of why aren't you going to die? Why are you guys still here? Here we are. Our growth rates never changed. We keep going up, we keep growing faster. And the goal is not to stop that. Um, so how have we done it thus far? One, we try to be ahead of their product roadmap, right? We want them copying us, not the other way around. And if it is the other way around, you can go ahead and pronounce us dead. Um, two is obviously just speed. And three is just leaning into accuracy. We we are not here to be, to make you, you know, feel good from every single answer. We're here to give you the most accurate answer to every question, not pump your tires in every response. And we fundamentally believe being five percent, ten percent, twenty percent more accurate over a long period of time is the winning solution. Awesome. Um, Maggie, could you share your experience growing Webflow from forty to one hundred and forty million users, especially the year into Covid. And I'll also add that do a plug for tomorrow. We actually have, um, Webflow CPO traffic tomorrow. So whoever asked the question make sure you come back. Um, but do you want to take that? Um, it was really tough. I mean, I think Webflow is really exceptional project, Rachel. I think it's Rachel. We didn't overlap. She came after I'd already gone to open AI um, we had we had just raised our series B from Excel, a really meaningful series B, we used that money to really invest in the sales team, in the product team, in marketing. We hadn't done a lot of marketing before that. Um, I'll be honest, it was a lot of Dragon Outbound, so I felt a really big sales tech team. I came in and built out a sales engine. They had very clear KPIs, what they had to go after, and it was kind of like through sheer grit and will, and I think it's still very much the same today. And that is the case in most enterprise companies is usually the customers won't just fall in your lap, you have to go out and get them. Awesome. Um, next question. How are you structuring your team to support their AI product? Um, I'll start, uh, we maybe to preface, we change our model. We've changed our model three times in the past year, and I think you just have to do that. Given the speed at which the market is changing, the technology is changing. The customers are changing. Like, for example, one year ago when I first joined intercom, a lot of the kind of objections we would get from prospects and customers would be, well, why do I need an AI agent for customer service? I'm not I'm not sold on that. We literally never have that question ever show up anymore. Uh, it actually is now like, well, how do I know that you have the best AI agent for what I'm trying to do? And like that, like in SaaS days, that would have been three years worth of evolution. But that happened in probably six months. Um, and so our teams have had to shift very rapidly. Um, we have solution engineers that support kind of like the pre-sales and, uh, technical discovery and solution design and things like that. Um, we have we do have a board deploy team that will execute starting from our POCs through to deployment. Um, and then we have a, a person that we call like a CX architect. And so it kind of speaks back to this idea of it's not just the technology we have to teach the customers about. You have to kind of support them from a change management organizational strategy perspective. And so we have an advisor that will work with our customers and teach them what the future looks like. And then we have success. And their job is to continue to optimize the outcomes that our customers get. So they drive up more resolutions from them. Um, and I'll

end with just one last question. Um, I just said I think companies are changing the directions all the time. How do you guys maintain the motivation when company decides to take a different direction than what you live in? You can potentially discuss this in your company and then what you believe in. Yeah, you have to decide if you're willing to get on board with it. And, um, you know, often things that are wrong, they're actually wrong. They will be reversed at some point. So it's can you get on board? Can you roll up your sleeves? The worst thing you can do is just continue to be that squeaky wheel fighting it. You can take a very data driven approach. I push back on things all the time throughout my career, and usually many times it'll reverse and go back the right way after people have experimented with things out. But if there's something that you just fundamentally can't get on board with, probably best to leave the company. I think you also have to kind of hire for this, like value of like resilience and idea that like you're expecting things to change. If you're expecting things to stay the same, you're probably with a company that's not growing, to be honest. Um, and so you actually have to come in and go with that mindset. Yeah. The last thing I'll add is just healthy friction is very, very good for product decisions. Um, a lot of this is intuition based. Like especially in AI right now, we have no clue what the next few years look like. Things are being reinvented, thrown away so quickly that you just have to have an open mind to experiment. You have to be extremely curious, and you can try stuff that you don't expect to work, but you still have to give it everything. And that's definitely something we try and hire for. Um, that will be in for the panel today. Let's give one around.